On a mission...

PHOTOGRAPH BY MARK BAKER

Practice makes perfect, what will you make this year?

We are now in the colder months of the year in the UK and I know many of us are very active in our workshops. As soon as spring and summer are here it seems there is a shift to the gardens and holidays, which all seems very logical to me. I have been talking to a lot of turners about buying and workshop habits. It seems, that in the UK – other countries will no doubt experience similar trends, but at different times – most turners are very active in the workshop, and also say they buy the most items for their workshop needs, between September and April/May. Outside of this time period workshop use seems to decline and so does their workshop spend. The 'peak' times of workshop activity seem also to correlate to when the most shows are staged too.

The clubs and other related organisations however, carry on throughout the year and events are planned to suit their needs. When talking to people, many say they are not as busy in their workshops during the warmer months and acknowledge that they are not getting the practice in at these times. When they eventually do increase their activities again, they struggle to remember some techniques and processes, having lost momentum and, of course, the more frequent use of them earlier in the year. One person told me that he gets so frustrated with himself about forgetting things he has done before that he broke a tool when he selected the wrong one for the project he was working on. That sounds extreme, but I am sure his frustration at not remembering something, is echoed by many.

I don't have a solution to the dilemmas of lack of workshop time other than trying to make sure we do allow, and also get time, for such things. Like many hobbys, crafts and pastimes, we often read about them more than have time to do them. I buy loads of magazines to read, but do not get the time to put all into practice. That is sad, but it is a fact and one that only we can do something about. It is a truism that practice makes perfect. If we don't practise we don't progress.

I am on a mission this year to get more people in the workshop and making. Even a small increase in the time spent at the lathe or practising your hobbies will have huge benefits in your confidence, sense of achievement and development of skills. Let me know what you end up making in your workshop.

Have fun,
Mark

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Woodworkers Institute website (**www.woodworkersinstitute.com**) is thriving. It would be great if you took a look and participated in the various discussions and competitions in our community, or see us on Facebook & Twitter.

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